



the special Chinese tea that Britons had grown to love, and plant them in India. When these seeds reached India, they merged with the indigenous Indian tea and gave rise to the tea industry in the country.

While Da Hong Pao is the most expensive tea in the world and available only at auctions, there is another Chinese tea that is pretty expensive. And while it doesn't have Ming dynasty connections, it is related to a rare animal found in China. The Panda Dung tea uses the panda's dung as fertiliser. This fertiliser is high in nutrients as pandas eat bamboo from which they absorb only 30 per cent of the nutrients. The balance remains in the droppings, which act as fertiliser for plants. The tea was first grown a decade ago in the Ya'an Mountains of China's Sichuan by an entrepreneur and panda enthusiast. Among much fanfare, the first batch was sold for \$3,500 (₹2.90 lakh) for 50 gm, making it one of the most expensive teas. It is no longer in production, making

Japanese tea is in high demand at tea auctions. Recently, less than a kg of hand-rolled green tea leaves from Japan sold for a record-breaking 1.96 million yen—or about ₹12.82 lakh

it a collector's item.

Now here's an exclusive tea that you can actually sip. The Yellow Gold Tea Buds from Singapore-based TWG Tea is priced at S\$611 (₹38,000) for 50 gm. What makes this Chinese yellow tea variety special? Each tea bud is covered with 24-carat gold, which once infused yields a delicately metallic and floral aftertaste. The company even gives instructions on preparing the tea. Pour 75° Celsius water over 2.5 gm of leaves per cup and infuse for 3-4 minutes. Remove leaves and serve.

TWG also sells Imperial Gyokuro, a rare Japanese tea of which only around 5 kg are harvested every year. The tea is painstakingly cultivated under handmade rice straw mats for three weeks. The tea absorbs significant quantities of minerals that wash through mats during rains and morning dew. Thanks to the shade, the jade-coloured tea grows very slowly developing a sweet and concentrated flavour. It is priced at S\$1,272 (₹80,000) for 50 gm and is